



India on a bicycle
A photographer
chronicles on the go

GO TO » PAGE 8

INSIDE
Exploring your country,
minus maps and social media

GO TO » PAGE 4

LITERARY REVIEW
Behind the scenes of a
fragile new nation

GO TO » PAGE 3

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COME FOR PROTEST, STAY FOR TEA

As India celebrates Independence Day, a quieter story of democracy is unfolding: in neighbourhoods, community kitchens and protest sites, where people are forming friendships and learning to trust one another



GETTY IMAGES

Neha Dixit

This July, during the student protests against the NEET exam paper leak, people from all over the country sent food, medical aid, water and other resources to the protest site in Delhi through app-based platforms. One evening, Ankit, who works part-time as a food delivery rider, arrived at Jantar Mantar with a parcel. There, he spotted Govind, who was helping distribute resources.

Ankit recognised him from the neighbourhood where he works mornings as a car cleaner. He walked up to Govind and told him how excited he was about the protests. The two hit it off almost immediately. “Every Sunday, Ankit would come home to pick up the car keys, but I had never made an effort to know more about him,” says Govind, a Delhi University undergraduate student. “I did not know that he was also a college-goer like me till I met him at Jantar Mantar.”

Over the next few days, they began spending time together at the protest site.

This Independence Day, perhaps the most important reminder for us as citizens is that democracy is rebuilt and sustained through dialogue and interaction. When people across socio-economic and political backgrounds connect, share grief and laughter, make friends, chat and get to know one another, they begin to build something more fundamental: trust.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGES 4-5



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WOMEN IN TRANSLATION MONTH



Geetanjali Shree (right) and Daisy Rockwell won the International Booker Prize in 2022 for *Tomb of Sand*. (GETTY IMAGES)

Aditya Vikram Shrivastava

It begins again with an old woman. She might be derelict, like Maa in the early pages of *Tomb of Sand*, but here, she has already died many deaths and turned to smoke that lingers in the rains.

In a city divided by riots, she wanders like a ghost, haunting this side and that. Detective, murderer, madwoman: floating rumours have made her everything everywhere all at once. The time is cruel. The city is segregated and numbed by profit-making corporations; but merely looking at her turns people into people again.

She appears, out of nowhere, on the rubble of a house being bulldozed, taking account of what is being lost. Or is spotted walking swiftly across the bridge, her cotton *pallu* flapping like the hawk's wing. This stubborn woman is memory herself, arriving like a sudden pang as we forget our own histories. Geetanjali Shree's fiction and Daisy Rockwell's translation move with the gait and spirit of this *budhiya* (old woman) in the titular story of their collection – crooked, lurching, springing, bracing.

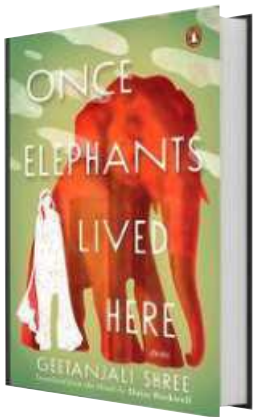
Shadow figures

Translated from the Hindi original, *Yahan Hathi Rahte The*, Shree's collection of short stories, *Once Elephants Lived Here* showcases great experimentation with literary form – turning the reader this way and that, playing with words, displacing beginning-middle-end, throwing sounds, sitting under a blooming tree for hours, or roaming in circles around the same place until something shifts.

Strung together by many unforgettable characters, especially a stellar cast of heroines, these stories wring the heart like a wet cloth and send a shudder down the shoulder. A striking line about missing elephants, from the first story, might encapsulate this book best: "Let them go the way of the elephants, wherever they went, with their joyful, lazy gait." Or maybe a rebellious inclination, that of "an old woman who did what she pleased".

DANCING TO THE WRITER'S SONG

The magic between author and translator is alive and brimming with possibilities in Geetanjali Shree and Daisy Rockwell's anthology, *Once Elephants Lived Here*



Once Elephants Lived Here
Geetanjali Shree, trs Daisy Rockwell
Penguin Hamish Hamilton
₹599

A shadow becomes a complete character, a shape-shifting thief who strikes fear in the heart of an old man, in "These Days". In a city where Muslims are being persecuted, and terror reigns, this story offers a moving revelation at

the end. Shree's game of withholding personhood in the figure of the shadow makes the story sharp and haunting.

The old father, a dying but domineering patriarch, in "The End" reminds us of the rich descriptions and crafty details that made up Shree's magnum opus, the International Booker Prize-winning *Tomb of Sand* (2022), also translated by Rockwell. The story ends with Ma, who speaks little otherwise, but mumbles such words on the father's passing that they might stay with us longer than his stupidity: "I am free now, free of responsibility, I can go wherever I want."

Avalanche of emotions
'Out for a Spin' bubbles with the narrator's frustrations, and somewhat hallucinatory repetitions. The spiral of despair, stitched into the form of the story, easily catches hold, and leaves us angry, wanting some air. 'Butterflies',

an account of young girls training to be nurses in Kerala, is quite confusing for a while. But it is also the most tender, even though it does not resolve the narrator's feelings or run as fast as the other stories.

'Echo' ends in a sentence so elaborate and winding that it snowballs a tiny emotion into an avalanche. The length of a large paragraph, this sentence seethes with the helplessness of a woman who wants to be strong but is weighed down by a history of violence that is as old as centuries, and grows and grows, spreading itself everywhere.

Memorable partnership
Rockwell's rendering of Shree's voice fits like a glove. Each noise seems to be coming from its rightful place, and dialogues sit well in the mouths of characters. While the Translator's Note mentions that 'So Much Sky' was the most unusual story in the collection, given its robotic people and a love affair with the sky, the translation conveys the narrator's love for life and openness brilliantly. She loves the sky, for it is the only thing that offers her true freedom. And, that long line in 'Echo' gives more evidence of the *Tomb of Sand* magic between writer and translator, which is certainly still alive. This *jugalbandi* is apparent in English, whether in the rhythm of the tales, in the way meaning floats rather than being overtly stated, or in how a sleight of hand in one language remains mysterious even in the other.

The last few stories have a sense of lightness that is unique. The characters here move with more quietness, but never lack depth. In the end, we are left with many things in our hands, feeling full of life, just like Shree's fictional women finding their freedom: "Ma, who was seventy, but also a young lady, began to dance beneath the sakura." We, too, will be found dancing to the writer's song. And when we return to these lines ages later, we shall find yet another song.

The reviewer, a poet and translator, teaches at Ashoka University.

Hope, round the corner

The International Booker-nominated Meiko Kawakami's new novel is about the brutality of life, but its focus on friendship and optimism keeps it afloat

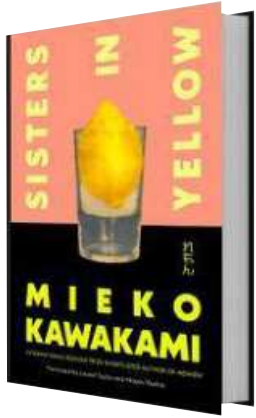
Radhika Santhanam
radhika.s@thehindu.co.in

In the hyper-modern city of Tokyo, which glows like a disco ball at night, there is no shortage of places to drink – pubs, cabaret clubs, host clubs, lounges, and more. Long ago, Meiko Kawakami worked in a bar, keeping men company as they drank, and has joked that she graduated from "hostess university".

In a piece in London's *Financial Times*, Kawakami wrote, "I get the sense that all that matters about being in – or moving through – society came to me via the people and the ways of this world at night." It is the people of this world – four nocturnal women – that the International Booker Prize-shortlisted author and poet brings to life in her latest novel, *Sisters in Yellow*, translated from the Japanese by Laurel Taylor and Hitomi Yoshio.

The world is stacked against these women – Hana, Kimiko, Ran and Momoko: if they suddenly disappeared, few would know or care. They live in a run-down house in the city, surviving on ramen and bento boxes from the convenience store. Their social life revolves mostly around McDonald's. When they are not working or looking for work, they spend their days watching television shows, the canned laughter providing a steady distraction from their dreary lives. And when life batters them with wave after wave, they find new ways to stay afloat, holding each other up.

This is a novel about the brutality of life, but its focus on the power of sisterhood and the unbridled optimism of



Sisters in Yellow
Meiko Kawakami, trs Laurel Taylor and Hitomi Yoshio
Picador
₹799

youth keeps it from becoming overwhelmingly bleak.

Dreams and reality

Sisters in Yellow begins as a thriller. At 40, Hana discovers from a newspaper article that her older friend Kimiko, who she hasn't been in touch with for decades, has been charged with "blackmail, abduction, and battery". The mention of Kimiko – a helpful and caring friend of Hana's mother, but always inscrutable – sends Hana into a spiral, and the past threatens to swallow her whole. Reading the article takes her, and us, back to her youth in the 1990s, when she ran away from her cramped, unlit house and unreliable mother.

With a stroke of luck, at just 15, Hana begins running a seedy bar with Kimiko. Hana names the bar Lemon, inspired by her belief in feng shui, where yellow signifies prosperity. Every night, Lemon fills up with smoke, drinks flow freely, and people sing karaoke, giving Hana joy and a sense of purpose she has not known before. When she meets two other girls close to her age, Ran and Momoko, she convinces them to work at the bar too. Hana thinks, "This... must be what they mean by the springtime of youth."

But their run ends abruptly when



Japanese writer and poet Meiko Kawakami. (GETTY IMAGES)

Lemon burns to a crisp one day. Out of a job and desperate, the straight-laced Hana finds herself making questionable decisions. She continues to hope that she will somehow be able to reopen Lemon with her chosen family.

Slowly, the novel turns into an indictment of inequality. Money is elusive for the poor, and when it does come into their hands, it disappears quickly – sometimes spent, sometimes stolen. Hana's "yellow corner", her small patch of hope, gathers dust.

An imperfect novel

Sisters in Yellow is a slow-burn, less interested in plot twists than in immersing the reader in its setting. In this, Kawakami is wonderful – you can smell the despair in the yellow paint that Hana uses to cover a wall, feel the warmth of hot hand towels in the bar, and taste the tantalising possibility of Hana's escape with her "sisters". There is sisterhood in the making of the novel too. The writer and translators are all women, and together, they capture not only the texture of late-'90s culture, but also the intimate worlds of the women.

It is when Kawakami slips into little lectures that the novel becomes overly didactic. En, a woman running a restaurant, tells Hana about money one night: "Save your own, all your own, save it and save it, and just sip off the top to make ends meet... 'Cause there's no guarantee or promises in this life."

Elsewhere, Kawakami writes, "People with money make the rules to help themselves, and poor people get sucked dry. And when you're all dried up, when you're nothing but dregs, they make you think it was your fault you failed at life."

The overly long exposition also gets tiring, especially when Kawakami curiously delves into details such as the mechanics of credit card fraud or gives us character backgrounds that feel tangential to the story.

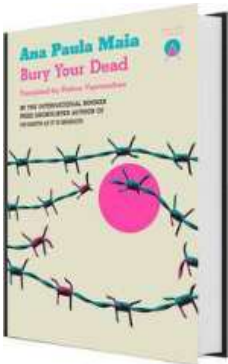
The novel is expansive, often rambling, yet gripping. Despite its flaws, I find myself dipping into its world days later. Perhaps it is Kawakami's storytelling and her profound understanding of the world she writes about that makes it a powerful portrait of despair, while hope continues to shine in every corner. Or, perhaps, it is simply Hana, forever trying to make the best of what she has.

BROWSER

Bury Your Dead

Ana Paula Maia, trs Padma Viswanathan
Charco Press
₹1,819 (ebook)

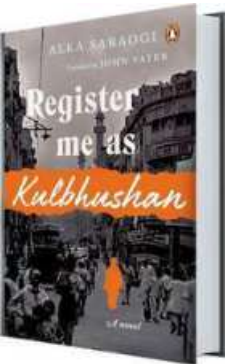
Known for her stark, visceral portrayal of marginalised lives, this new novel by the International Booker-shortlisted author presents a world where the boundaries between life and death, humanity and brutality, steadily blur.



Register Me as Kulbhushan

Alka Saraogi, trs John Vater
Penguin
₹599

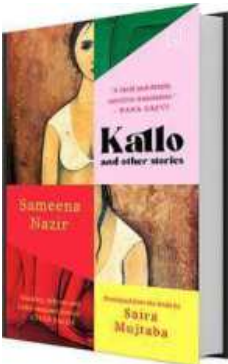
Translated from Hindi, the story moves between memories of Partition, displacement and the present, exploring the many identities a person acquires while searching for a place to belong. Saraogi navigates this terrain with sensitivity and nuance.



Kallo and Other Stories

Sameena Nazir, trs Saira Mujtaba
Hachette India
₹599

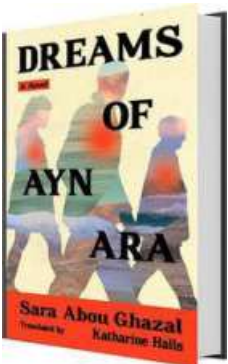
First published in Urdu in 2021, this acclaimed collection marks the English debut of Pakistani writer Nazir. Its irreverent stories centre women who challenge social conventions around gender, caste, class and sexuality.



Dreams of Ayn Ara

Sara Abou Ghazal, trs Katharine Halls
Feminist Press
₹1,700 (ebook)

Translated from the Arabic, this debut novel by the Palestinian feminist writer follows the Abu Sukkar family, displaced from their ancestral village in Palestine after the 1948 Nakba. Each chapter is narrated by a different family member.



Remaking of identity

Through personal memories and political observations, Qurratulain Hyder recounts how people’s lives were changed by Partition



Urdu novelist, academic and journalist Qurratulain Hyder. (PTI)

Simar Bhasin

Qurratulain Hyder is considered a pioneer in modern Urdu writing with a repertoire that includes short stories, novels, and works in translation. *A Tilt in Time: Partition & Pakistan – a mid-century memoir* (Women Unlimited Ink) is the English translation by scholar Fatima Rizvi of Parts 12 to 15 of Hyder’s autobiographical work *Kar-e Jahan Daraz Hai* (volume II) and traverses the decade just after Partition. Rizvi notes in her introduction that every act of translation involves intentional “linguistic, semantic, and cultural negotiations”. One, then, wonders what nuances of Hyder’s Urdu might have got lost in an English translation of her work. But Rizvi’s careful translation preserves Hyder’s wit and her astute observations of the intellectual elites and the political movers and shakers of her generation.

Remaking of community Hyder describes her relatives who migrated from Nehtaur in Uttar Pradesh to Pakistan as “being akin to the pilgrim fathers of the Mayflower”. What she archives is not the traumatic series of events that unfolded with the announcement of Partition, but rather, how the everyday was experienced by those who lived through this mass displacement.

It was a time when “young men and women were trying their best to equip themselves in novel ways of living”. These sections provide glimpses of Lahore, Karachi, Dhaka, Delhi, and London, with Hyder continuing her own quest for belonging as a writer and intellectual, while bearing witness to one of the most defining moments in the history of the Indian subcontinent.

As Hyder moves across the newly formed nation-state, the reader is made privy to conversations on what might constitute Pakistani culture, distinct from what was considered Indian heritage. To borrow from the historian Benedict Anderson, how do you cultivate national belonging when the community is yet to be fully imagined?

Hyder notes that the “greatest tragedy of the generation that experienced Partition” was that “they were shattered within”. She intersperses critical political and social observations with poignant moments that offer glimpses into what such a “shattering” looked like, which makes the text accessible.

An instance of this is when her extended relatives and friends gather to share their own personal experiences of the violence that accompanied Partition. In this storytelling session, a betel nut box was placed “in the centre, like a lamp in a *mushaira*” as each participant took turns to recount their personal encounters with tragedy when their families were forced to migrate out of their generational homes. The individual stories soon become a communal acknowledgement of shared

helplessness, where a story begun by one narrator is completed by another in the following words: “And when it occurred to you, one day, the revolution had failed, that bourgeois politics had come to an end and new governments and capitalist economies had come into being in both countries, you felt it did not matter where you lived...” This intimate circle captures what the cultural theorist Homi Bhabha conceptualised as the ‘community of the unhomely’ – moments or points of fissure in postcolonial writing that show the inevitable entanglement of the private and the political. This is what the reader is made to share in: the unmaking and remaking of community in times of extreme distress. Hyder’s account of a world in flux is also accompanied by lighter moments, especially of human connections and community-building endeavours. These included intellectual *baithaks* that mirrored French salons, where the poet Faiz Ahmad Faiz could be heard reciting his latest work, or the writer Dr. Mulk Raj Anand could be found discussing his understanding of socialist humanism. At one gathering, Hyder asks the great-granddaughter of Bahadur Shah Zafar, the last Mughal emperor, why, at a time when “a lot of people are filing false claims on properties they left behind in India,” she would not lodge a claim on the Red Fort – one that she could argue would actually be lawful.



A Tilt in Time: Partition & Pakistan Qurratulain Hyder Women Unlimited Ink ₹900

Hyder also narrates her confrontations with patriarchal workplaces and recounts anecdotes, such as her participation in a London protest against the Rosenberg convictions during the McCarthy witch hunts.

Past in the present All of this makes the memoir a pertinent read for the uncertain times in which we continue to live. The questions raised in *A Tilt in Time* are as valid now as they were then: how does one reconcile the postcolonial inheritance of the democratic nation-state as a political structure with a geographical polity that is as diverse as the Indian subcontinent? Are democratic values, and by extension human rights, conditional? Why are women discriminated against in the workforce despite contributing more to the economy in terms of unpaid domestic labour as well as through their active employment? What *A Tilt in Time* presents to the 21st-century reader is hinted at in its title itself: a negotiation with time as both a temporal and spatial experience, moving beyond a linear progression to offer a way of looking at the past, while also inviting a renewed understanding of the present.

The reviewer is a literary critic and research scholar who lives in Delhi.

80th
INDEPENDENCE DAY



(from far left) Hanwant Singh; Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel; C.P. Ramaswami Aiyar; V.P. Menon. Menon and Patel worked to prevent the Balkanisation of India, while Singh and Iyer sought to protect their State’s sovereignty. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

SILENT ARCHITECTS OF THE REPUBLIC

Josy Joseph’s book narrates the stories of civil servants, spies, and negotiators who worked behind the scenes to hold a fragile new nation together

Amritesh Mukherjee

The recent images of police brutality against students during the non-violent Cockroach Janata Party-led protests shocked and mobilised a nation supposedly too apathetic to care. They also raised a question: how did we become subjects rather than citizens, governed by a state that inflicts violence on the very population it claims to serve? To understand why freedoms are so contested, we must first understand how our nation won its independence.

We like to imagine history as a slow march of ants, patiently accumulating sand until they build a mound. But history is just as often a boot coming down in a sudden stamp, compressing decades of change in weeks. Josy Joseph’s *Birth of a Nation: The Twenty-One Days That Made India* is a thriller disguised as history, capturing three frenetic weeks between July 25 and August 14, 1947, when bureaucrats, princes, ministers, and spies raced against time to prevent Balkanisation and accomplish “nothing less than the creation of an independent nation.” The book is the product of a decade-long excavation: Joseph and a research team pored over declassified State Department records, royal private papers, and MIS files to construct a meticulously dated timeline.

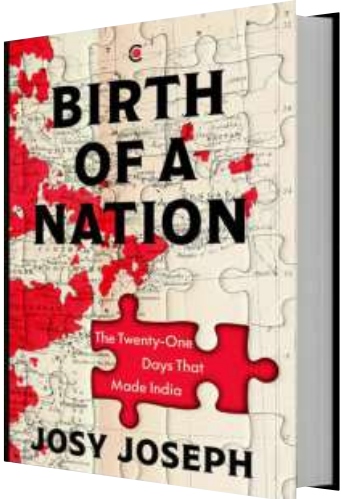
Struggle for a united India In the summer of 1947, freedom had at least three competing definitions: “the Congress, determined to create a republic,” the Muslim League “hell-bent on an independent Pakistan,” and the powerful princely states, “a third front determined to be

independent of both.” When power is at stake, ideology bends easily; hence one of history’s ironies: both the Hindu Mahasabha and the Muslim League, which were bitter rivals, endorsed the princely states’ right to resist integration.

Between the podiums and the flag hoisting, many battles were being fought that summer. Sir Conrad Corfield, private secretary to the Viceroy, ordered the organised destruction of confidential files carrying the princes’ secrets and scandals – his one last act to protect his old clients from the country about to inherit them. Trying to prevent him and the fragmentation of India was the States Department, hurriedly assembled under Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and V.P. Menon. “[Their] objective was to create a united India while minimising the chaos – a process that meant coaxing, cajoling, threatening, and, if needed, confronting rulers and pushing them into accession,” writes Joseph.

Menon, a former mine worker who served as constitutional adviser to the Viceroy, knew that asking the princes for everything would be rejected, so he asked for almost nothing: just Defence, External Affairs, and Communications, leaving their wealth and internal rule

We like to imagine history as a slow march of ants, patiently accumulating sand until they build a mound. But history is just as often a boot coming down in a sudden stamp, compressing decades of change in weeks



Birth of a Nation: The Twenty-One Days That Made India Josy Joseph ₹795 Westland

untouched. Menon (and many like him) may rarely appear in the 1947 textbook version, but his impact was immeasurable. As Joseph says, the standard narrative of Independence centres on “the Gandhian non-violent movement” and the spotlight is on the “towering personalities of that period.” What gets lost in the process are “the remarkable stories” of those who worked “in the shadows cast by these titans” to build a united India. Here, he pulls a new cast of shadow players from beneath the familiar titans of 1947.

Unfinished task of freedom Defiance, that summer, wore many disguises. There was scale in Hyderabad, a state so massive – “larger than England and Scotland combined” – that its independence alone could have redrawn the subcontinent. In Junagadh, there was deception, as the Dewan publicly courted Delhi while privately signing the accession to Pakistan, a fact

revealed only on the morning of the 15th. In Jodhpur, there was brinkmanship: the Maharaja pulled a pen-pistol on Menon before accepting Delhi’s terms over Jinnah’s. And in Travancore, it took an assassination attempt on Dewan C.P. Ramaswami Aiyar to crumple a sovereignty project that had, until July 25, seemed unstoppable.

Even the Northeast carried its own unfinishedness into the new republic, from a Naga accord that broke almost as soon as it was signed to a Tripura absorbing refugees while its own succession stayed uncertain. In short, “India was being born amid unfinished arguments. The princes were still bargaining for privilege, the provinces were already bleeding, the hill peoples were demanding to be heard before being absorbed.”

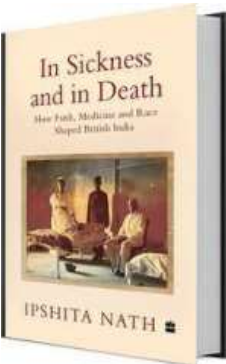
At the stroke of the midnight hour, Joseph writes that “some danced on the streets; others hid behind shuttered doors. It was a night of hope and uncertainty, of joy and of fear.” The incompleteness held even then. Minutes after Jawaharlal Nehru delivered his famous ‘tryst with destiny’ address, Lord Mountbatten opened an envelope expecting to find the new cabinet’s names. Only a blank sheet of paper stared back – a republic still waiting to take shape.

Nearly eight decades on, the thrones have vanished, but the reflex that built them – the instinct to centralise, to govern subjects rather than raise citizens – has outlasted them. As the book reminds us, a republic is hard-won; its preservation depends on understanding its roots.

The reviewer is a journalist, writer, and editor.

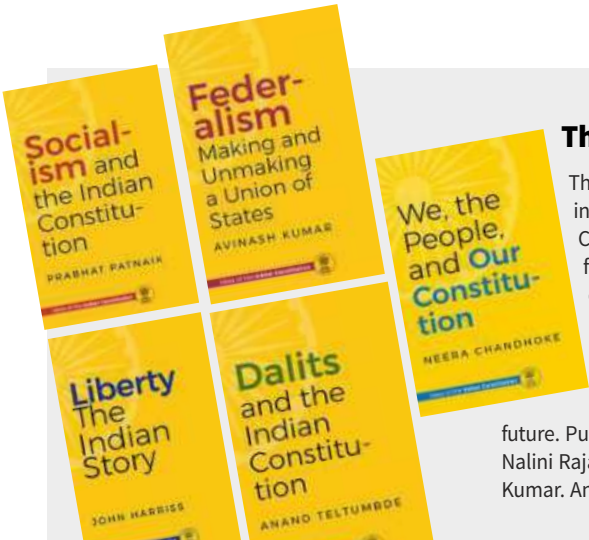
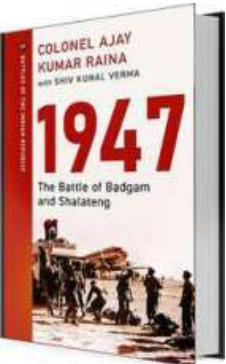
In Sickness and In Death

Ipshita Nath Harper Collins ₹799 Nath examines how the colonial state studied, managed, and often misunderstood diseases, and the ‘diseased body’, in India. She reveals how disease reshaped policy, contested imperial ambition and altered everyday life.



1947: The Battle of Badgam and Shalateng

Colonel Ajay Kumar Raina, Shiv Kunal Verma Aleph Book Company ₹499 This book by Col. Raina and military historian Verma draws on military records and accounts to revisit a crucial but often overlooked chapter of the Kashmir conflict.



The Ideas of the Indian Constitution

This seven-book series (published by Speaking Tiger) offers an accessible introduction to the values and vision of India’s founding document. Conceived as a tribute to the freedom struggle, the series draws on the freedom movement, Constituent Assembly debates, and the constitutional journey of independent India. It explores key ideas including secularism, socialism, democracy, justice, liberty, equality, fraternity, federalism, and the scientific temper. At a time when these principles are increasingly contested, the series reaffirms the Constitution’s moral vision and relevance to India’s democratic future. Published titles include works by Neera Chandhoke, Prabhat Patnaik, Nalini Rajan, Anand Telumbde, Rajmohan Gandhi, John Harris, and Avinash Kumar. An eighth book by S. Irfan Habib is expected in September.

CONTINUED FROM
» PAGE 1

A story of almonds

Some of the strongest solidarities are built not through grand political acts, but through everyday exchanges.

Back in 2009, I heard a joke among the women almond workers of Delhi: that women who shell and package California almonds learn how to eat with a spoon.

I heard this joke at the home of Nisha 'Radiowali' in Karawal Nagar in Northeast Delhi, while working on my book, *The Many Lives of Syeda X*. The women earned roughly ₹150 a day for shelling up to 80 kg of California almonds over 12-16 hours. The almonds were sometimes softened with acid before being shelled, or shelled directly with their nails. The work corroded their fingertips, making it difficult to eat Indian food without a spoon.

All the women I met were piece-rate workers who had migrated to Delhi for work. They came from different religions and castes, and worked in isolated spaces, with nowhere to meet or spend time together. That changed when Nisha, a single woman around their age, moved into the area as a supervisor at a scrapyard. Her home soon became known as 'Radiowali ka ashram', an *adda*. The women called her 'Radiowali' because she had spent decades working in Delhi's electronics industry; at one point, she even made radio transmitters.

Unlike the other women workers, whose homes were largely controlled by their husbands and children, Nisha could receive visitors on her own terms. She did not have a

husband and earned more than the others. The women would drop in to nap, watch television, chat, or share a *paratha* or a packet of biscuits over *chai* before returning to their arduous work. Most did not even think of themselves as "workers", despite working up to 16 hours a day. They saw their earnings simply as a way to "buy groceries", "pay for children's fees" or "pay the house rent".

"No one heard us – husbands, contractors, supervisors. But we started hearing each other," recalls Syeda, Nisha's friend.

Friendship and trust slowly built over time, finally giving the women the confidence to fight for better wages. In 2009, they held one of the biggest and longest strikes by unorganised workers in India, leading to a 40% jump in the price of almonds globally. The protest was a success, and their wages were increased.

Bridging the distance

Sometimes, spaces of solidarity emerge organically. At other times, they have to be created. ChalChitra Abhiyaan, a cultural and media collective, was set up in Shamli district of Uttar

Pradesh in 2016, in response to the deepened polarisation following the 2013 Muzaffarnagar and Shamli sectarian riots that displaced almost 1,00,000 working-class Muslims. One of its initiatives was to organise community film screenings in villages across western Uttar Pradesh. In the region, villages and neighbourhoods remain deeply segregated along caste and religious lines.

"We began film screenings in Dalit *chaupals*. Usually, neither upper caste people nor Muslims enter these spaces. But gradually, land-owning farmers from dominant castes – both Hindus and Muslims – and field workers from marginalised castes – again, both Hindus and Muslims – have started attending these community screenings. Some of them even participate in post-screening discussions," says Sachin Jawla, a member of ChalChitra Abhiyaan.

When they watch *Phule*, a film on anti-caste activists and education reformers Savitri and Jyotirao Phule, the discussion naturally veers towards the challenges young girls across communities face when it comes to education. When they

watch *Pandit Usman*, a short film on a man who receives a heart from a donor of another faith, people laugh together at the idiosyncrasies of religious leaders.

"To make people sit next to each other in an area where neighbours burnt down each other's houses, is an achievement in itself," says Jawla. There are hardly any public spaces in the area, except religious ones. "Through these collective cultural forums, people at least have the option of becoming friends," he adds.

Neighbourhood deep-dive

In a post-truth era, when emotionally charged propaganda can be difficult to counter with facts alone, regular interactions can help break down stereotypes.

The 'Know Your Neighbour' campaign in Kolkata was one such attempt to fight prejudice through encounters between people who might otherwise never meet.

In 2016, around the time of the West Bengal Assembly elections, a series of low-level riots and sectarian tensions heightened communal anxieties. Almost everything



was being viewed through a communal lens. "Apart from the bigoted narratives in the mainstream media, we realised that even well-meaning people had prejudices. It came from ignorance," says Mohammad Reyaz, a teacher at a Kolkata university and a volunteer with 'Know Your Neighbour'.

The campaign organised neighbourhood walks to help people see beyond these assumptions. "A lot of urban professionals have never been to a Muslim ghetto. They end up believing stereotypes about Muslim women in hijab or what a Muslim neighbourhood looks like," says Reyaz.

These were not heritage walks. They were designed to introduce people to the lives and communities around them – migrant workers from Bihar, for instance, as well as highly placed

Muslim women professionals. Since these neighbourhoods are largely under-researched and undocumented, some participants went on to write collaborative research papers about them.

Recent walks have included visits to Kolkata's oldest Chinatown, Armenian churches and Parsi synagogues that co-exist within a Muslim neighbourhood. "At the end of the day, we all have to live next to each other – no one is leaving," says Reyaz. "These interactions definitely improve society, if not immediately change it."

Age of the *andolanjevi*

The idea of creating spaces for people to meet takes on an even larger meaning during protests. Over the years, protests have become more

than sites of political dissent. At one point, Prime Minister Narendra Modi even scorned the protesters by calling them *andolanjevi*, or "protest parasites".

But beyond marching against the government, many protest sites have also become shared public spaces for cultural exchange – places where people from varied backgrounds meet, talk, eat, sing, and get to know each other. They might otherwise never have encountered.

During the anti-CAA (Citizenship Amendment Act) protests in 2019, Kunal M., a teacher at a media school, regularly joined the human chains formed to protect Muslim protesters as they offered *namaaz* at the site. "I am a staunch atheist. I used to argue with my friends who



were believers. I had seen so much religious bigotry that I hated rituals and anything to do with religion. But here, I realised that people find hope in various ways and prayer

(Clockwise from left) A protest against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act in Delhi in February 2020; farmers at the Singhu border in Delhi, February 2021; and the student protest in Delhi's Jantar Mantar last month. (GETTY IMAGES, SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA AND R.V. MOORTHY)



When the COVID-19 pandemic hit a few months later and the first nationwide lockdown was imposed in March 2020, several protest participants like Kunal became relief volunteers almost overnight. By then, a well-oiled machinery was already in place to provide food and other essentials to those in need, including thousands of migrant workers forced to walk home after the government failed to provide for their survival. In the process, a broader solidarity cutting across caste and class began to take shape.

Later that year, on November 26, 2020, the Indian government introduced three farm laws that farmers feared would leave them more vulnerable to corporate buyers. The laws triggered one of the largest and longest farmers' protests in modern India.

80th
INDEPENDENCE DAY



For those 13 months at the farmers' protest site, I had to cook, clean vessels and wash clothes. And then do it again the next day. I realised how much work women have to do at home

MANJEET SINGH
Farmer, Punjab



A lot of urban professionals have never been to a Muslim ghetto. They end up believing stereotypes about Muslim women in hijab or what a Muslim neighbourhood looks like

MOHAMMED REYAZ
Volunteer, 'Know Your Neighbour', Kolkata



To make people sit next to each other in an area where neighbours burnt down each other's houses, is an achievement in itself

SACHIN JAWLA
ChalChitra Abhiyaan, Shamli, U.P.

protests in modern India. Millions of farmers, many of them Sikh, travelled from across the country and gathered on Delhi's borders after being stopped from entering the capital. They built makeshift shelters around their tractors and trolleys and stayed for months.

The bonds between Muslim and Sikh protesters had begun to take shape earlier that year. *Langar sewa*, the Sikh tradition of serving free food to all from community kitchens, is an integral part of Sikh religious practice. During the anti-CAA protests, Sikh volunteers had distributed food and other essentials at protest sites for days. When the farmers' movement began, Muslim volunteers responded by setting up community kitchens for everyone at the protest sites. Sikh protesters, in turn, formed human chains to protect Muslims as they prayed.

Manjeet Singh, a farmer from Ferozepur in Punjab, was part of one such chain. "The mainstream media had demonised Muslims so much that when we actually met them, we felt so angry at the media," he says.

Apart from religious solidarity, the protest built empathy across gender lines too. "For those 13 months at the protest site, I had to cook, clean vessels and wash clothes. And then do it again the next day. I realised how much work women have to do at home," adds Singh.

After returning home, Singh remains in regular touch with the friends he made in Delhi. They advise him on which car to buy and which courses his children should enrol in. He, in turn, invites them to Ferozepur, which he insists is

far cleaner and prettier than Delhi in winter.

Democracy is built on institutions and principles. But it survives through human coordination: the everyday acts of solidarity and trust forged over food, songs, dance, jokes, cultural exchanges and personal connections.

Demonstration sites to cultural spaces

The student protests in July this year were, in many ways, a culmination of the civic engagement that had taken shape over the previous few years.

After the July 20 police crackdown on students in Delhi demanding Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation, it was hardly surprising that the protest site at Jantar Mantar, dismantled by the police that morning, was rebuilt by students that same evening. It was as if a kind of muscle memory had been activated – years of collaborative empathy, built one movement at a time, had become instinctive.

The community kitchens of earlier protests also found new forms. Food delivery apps made it possible for people to send meals and supplies directly to the protest sites, while contributions poured in from across India. This was not simply an expression of anger at the government. People had been moved by what the protesters had endured. On the Internet, memes, jokes, songs and laughter became another way of connecting – often more powerfully than political slogans or jargon – by turning outrage into something personal and shared.

Neha Bora, a student activist, says people across generations and social groups moved when the parents of protesters began coming to her to apologise. "They said they were ashamed of voting for the ruling party, the BJP," she says.

has been affected by the government's disappointing education policies. But what finally made the issue deeply personal for many were their own children and friends, who had taken to the streets to demand accountability and were brutally beaten. Bora herself sat on a hunger strike for 23 days over question-paper leaks in competitive exams. She recalls being particularly moved when the parents of protesters began coming to her to apologise. "They said they were ashamed of voting for the ruling party, the BJP," she says.

The protest sites at Jantar Mantar and elsewhere across India have become more than places of political dissent. They were turned into cultural fairs – spaces for celebration, catharsis and belonging.

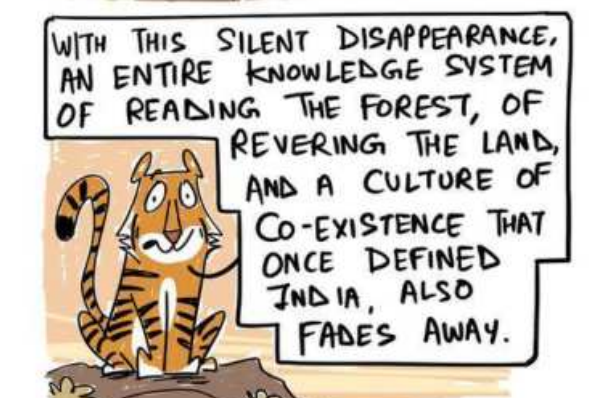
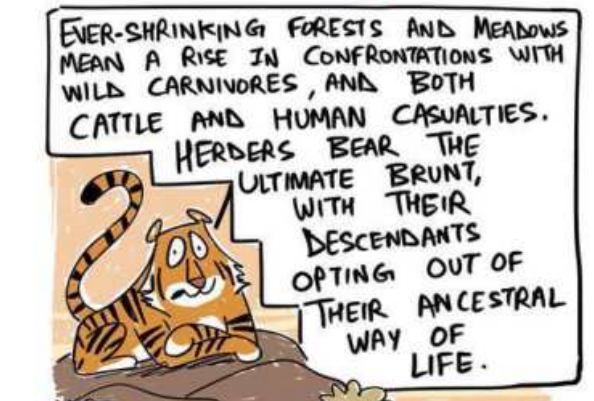
India is unlikely to reclaim its democracy through a handful of campaigns or protests alone. But it may be rebuilt slowly, from the bottom up: through solidarity networks before political parties, friendships before grand alliances, local trust before national consensus, and hope before victory. The work has already begun, even if the destination remains far away. It is happening quietly, steadily, unevenly and imperfectly.

Almost a month after the student protests, Govind and Ankit remain in touch, exchanging memes and messages on social media. Recently, they went to a theatre to watch the Diljit Dosanjh-starrer *Main Vaapas Aaunga*. "It was my treat," Ankit says.

The writer is a Delhi-based independent journalist and the author of *The Many Lives of Syeda X* (2024).

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan ChakOravarty



A HIDDEN LAKE OF LOTUSES

Of wrong turns and happy accidents while exploring India, and the thrill of arriving before maps told you where to go

Nisha Vikram

My 8-year-old thinks I have no chill. Her friends go to South Korea and come back with those plastic anime toys. They go to Paris and eat croissants at a café that is famous on Instagram. They go to a Scandinavian country for a white Christmas. And here I am, telling her that our next vacation is a trip to Hazaribagh in Jharkhand to visit artisans who paint cave

painting-inspired murals on the walls of their homes during the harvest season. No wonder she believes I am the root of all her woes!

But I have always travelled differently. In 2008, I was still in my corporate job. At a party, I met a friend's friend. A week later, she asked if I would be interested in a monsoon trip to Goa, inspired by British travel writer Alexander Frater's book *Chasing the Monsoon: A Modern Pilgrimage Through India* (2011, Picador). We would take a train from Mumbai, meet her other

friends, and drive down the coast chasing the rain. I said yes to a trip with strangers built around a book about weather.

It has been by far the best trip of my life. We were draped throughout. I drank a full bottle of toddy because I didn't know what so much of the innocently sweet-tasting thing would do and I laughed for three hours straight. We trekked up Yana caves in Gokarna, Karnataka, pulled our car out of mud, slept in dorms. Those people are my family now. If not for them,

there would be no CraftCanvas, my design studio that works with over 30 craft traditions across India and brings artisanal work into contemporary spaces. They were the first ones to pull out their cheque-books to say, 'Go live your dream. We've got your back.'

A few years later in Istanbul, my husband and I took the bus till the last stop and stumbled upon a row of pastel-hued homes, ate local bakery bread, and spent our days like locals, somehow imagining we lived there. A lesson I have carried

Many Indias (Clockwise from left) On the road to Chamba District, Himachal Pradesh; Chamba Rural artisan Padma Shri Lalita Vakli in 2017; a village temple festival in Upper Kinnaur in 2015; a lotus pond somewhere between Tamil Nadu's Kumbakonam and Thanjavur in 2014; stone carvers in Shivrapattana, Kolar District, Karnataka, in 2011. (NISHA VIKRAM)



back with me to my trips within India.

Chance encounters, to me, are what distinguishes travel from tourism. Travel evokes a particular line from singer Lucky Ali's popular song 'Dekha Hai Aise Bhi': "Nazare bhi humse mile." The sights will come to meet you. It is my life anthem, to not chase the experience but allow it to find you. And be slow, unscheduled, and present enough for this to work. Be willing to stop the auto to answer nature's call, and discover a hidden lake full of giant lotuses on the other side of a raised mound. That lake in Tamil Nadu, between Kumbakonam and Thanjavur, was not in any guidebook. There was no location pin. We found it because we were not trying to find anything.

Looking for craft villages I have been travelling to craft locations across India since 2009, before Instagram existed, before Google Maps covered the roads I was taking. The methodology has been simple. I look up the village in the *Handmade in India*, by textile designer and design thinker Aditi and M.P. Ranjan (2007), and head there. Someone in the village would know the artisan. Everything would come together from that point.

In 2011, a friend and I drove towards Shivrapattana in Karnataka to find stone carvers with nothing but a printed page from the book and a Nokia GPS that gave up past Kolar. A tea-shop owner sent a local boy with us the rest of the way. In 2017, I travelled to Chamba in Himachal Pradesh in my third trimester, threw up along the way, conducted a meeting supine on embroidery artist Padma Shri Lalita Vakli's couch, and pushed furniture against my hotel door. All because my photographer friend went for picturesque over practical and had booked us into a shady, remote hotel, reached only on foot. When morning came, there was a magnificent river in front of us, with giant flowers and butterflies everywhere.

On a craft-scouting trip to Upper Kinnaur in Himachal in 2015, our group arrived late

and ended up at the temple on the night of the annual festival. Arrack was passed as an offering to the goddess. The village head had to intervene after several rounds. Every married lady that night wore her bridal dress and jewellery, all hand-woven and crafted over years. For my line of work, this was treasure. I had stumbled into something I had no way of knowing was happening.

Today, these villages will likely have location pins and reels about them. That tea stall probably has a Zomato rating. Artisans have Instagram pages, WhatsApp numbers and order catalogues, and it is wonderful. Less information asymmetry means an artisan does not have to wait for someone like me to show up for an order. There is no denying that those days were often harder, for the artisan more than for me.

As most things in life, however, two things can be true at once. Somebody's pin might be the reason an artisan's daughter can afford college this year. And I long for the sort of adventure that is getting harder to seek out.

Chance encounters

But the romantic that I am, I still stick to my methodology. The willingness to arrive without a fixed expectation of the outcome, and to be genuinely curious about what I encounter.

With this mindset, the artisan may sit with you for hours sharing stories that no influencer was privy to. And if you are lucky, even feed you rice, *aloo posto* and his share of the fish. True story, mind you.

The monuments of Rajasthan are incredible and you can stand in front of them and feel something stir inside you. But to me, the answers lie in the tea stall, in a temple on a festival night, in a hidden lake that only belongs to you.

My daughter will find this for herself, in her own time. For me, the most alive I have ever felt in a place was when I let the unpredictable remind me that I am part of something larger than myself.

The Bengaluru-based writer is the founder of CraftCanvas, a design studio in Bengaluru and Ahmedabad.



ALLEGEDLY

Forgiving is such fun

A long-overdue apology to everyone who has survived the writer

not only for myself, but also on behalf of the Yamaha RX100, a proud two-wheeler that's quite conscious of its image.

So I accelerated and easily overtook them. But instead of upshifting with the gear pedal to match the acceleration, my foot pressed down on the brake. The Yamaha decelerated sharply, right in front of the elderly Lambretta. The old man, in trying to avoid a collision, braked hard. He lost control, his scooter swerved like crazy, and went

zig-zag for a bit before crashing into a lamppost. As I sped away, I glimpsed them in my rear-view mirror, sprawled on the ground, staring after me in disbelief. I don't know if they are still around – probably not. But today is the day I come clean. I want to tell this uncle-aunt, if they are reading this from heaven, that I completely and unequivocally forgive them.

Fire, forget, forgive

A decade or so later, when I was accidentally employed in

the corporate sector, I was given a target to reduce my team strength by five. But I misheard five as 13. Naturally, I fired 15 people, because my policy as an employee was to always exceed expectations. I deactivated their official emails, and sent them a one-line text message saying their services are no longer needed. When they reached the office, I had them turned away from the main gate after having their IDs and company stationery confiscated. My bosses were so thrilled they gave me a double promotion. Today, I forgive those extra 10 people I laid off. You know who you are. I have no hard feelings though none of you apologised for thinking bad thoughts about me – as I'm sure you all must have.

Finally, my third-best friend Alok. Until recently, he kept beating me in chess. But I more than made up for it by dominating him in Snakes and Ladders, a far superior game of strategy and intellect. But after routing me seven consecutive times, Alok became so arrogant that I realised I needed to teach him a lesson, for his own good. So I suggested that whoever loses the next chess match should take the other out for booze at the Seven Seasons luxury hotel. He agreed. So I cheated, and won. I made Alok spend ₹17,000 in one evening as we both got hammered.

I never beat him in chess again, partly because I never cheated again. I must add that I never cheated again partly because he never gave me another opportunity. For some unknown reason he will not say, he has stopped playing chess with me. Now you understand why he's only my third-best friend. Nonetheless, I forgive him. I am sure one day we will become best friends.

G. Sampath, the author of this satire, is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

Nitin Chaudhary

One of the freedoms of being Indian today is the freedom to leave India, make a home elsewhere. Leaving a country, however, does not necessarily mean leaving behind the part of you that belongs to it. So, on a sultry New York afternoon, the question “Where are you from?” came as a surprise. We had been talking for 10 minutes. He was wearing a Brazilian soccer shirt, half-wet from the sweat pouring down his bald head. I hesitated to answer. Shouldn’t he have figured out by now, from my accent, that I was Indian? But was I really from India? Would it not be Sweden, the place I had called home for the last 20 years? I gave my roundabout answer: I was born in India, but Sweden is home now. For the last year, though, I have been here in the U.S. America doesn’t feel like home, merely a transit point before I head back to Sweden. I left the last part out. It reeked of homesickness. A disorder I have suffered from ever since I moved from Malmö to Texas a year ago. Texas has treated me well, though, even as I learnt new ways and let go of the old. Could I make it my new home? I shuddered at the thought. I had come here for work, not because Texas was a place I had imagined making my own, and I longed to see a different, less uniform America. Surely, this could not be the only America that existed. I needed a getaway. New York was the respite I sought.

Nowhere and everywhere I headed straight to Times Square,



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

WHERE AM I FROM?

A seemingly simple question becomes complicated when home, identity and belonging span three continents

where soccer fans had gathered ahead of 2026 FIFA World Cup Brazil versus Morocco group match in June. Knicks fans, the locals, were everywhere and, at once, difficult to spot. Among them was Ale. Ten minutes into standing together, shoulder to shoulder, shouting into each other’s ears, he leaned in and

asked, “Where are you from?” Where is one from? Why do we have this natural urge to know this fact? We ask because it becomes a way to place an individual on our mental map. Humans are storytelling animals; we want to know the first chapter. But for me, the question has become a trap. I have never found a

perfect script to answer it without narrating all the transitions in my life. An easy escape is to say that I am from India. I see the other person’s face relax, as if they have solved a simple chess puzzle. But I also feel conflicted, as if I have lied. And yet, there is unquestionably a part of me that is Indian. It is the

oldest part. India contains my childhood, school years, the small town where I spent the first 18 years of my life and Delhi, where I studied before leaving the country. It survives even in the accent that made me assume Ale should have known where I was from. Sweden may be home, but India remains the place where the first version of me was made. Even within India, I complicate my origin story. When asked where I was from, I would say Delhi. Did I really belong there? I had only spent four years in the city. I did not want to mention the small town where I grew up in, a place I assumed no one would have heard of. So, knowingly, I lied. Palestinian-American postcolonial theorist Edward Said writes that birthplace and belonging can be separated. For a migrant, this innocent question can reopen a complicated geography. Here in Times Square, I chose the easier option, betraying my layered answer for convenience. The outsider-insider The next morning, I met Yuriy at Carnegie Diner & Café. Having lived here for 14 years, the U.S. citizen is Ukrainian by birth. “Where are you from?” I asked. “Right now, it seems like I belong nowhere,” he said. “Here, despite the citizenship, I feel like an outsider. I can’t go back home either. There, the authorities have sent my serving papers.” Papers summoning him to serve in the Ukrainian army. “If I do, they will enlist me, and

who knows if I will be able to come back to the States.” We drank the rest of our coffee in silence. Here was Yuriy, alone in a country not of his birth, feeling alien but with no escape. What about his children, I asked as we got up to leave. Did they feel at home here? “Oh yes,” Yuriy said, a smile returning. “For them, this is their world.” There was hope in that answer. My short escape to New York was coming to an end. The conversation with Yuriy had comforted me. Unlike him, I had a place I considered home and could return to. Such safety, I realised, is not easily available to all migrants. I still cannot convincingly answer the question of where I am from. But as I left New York, the question felt a little less like a trap. Maybe I did not have to choose one place and betray the others. The Indian in me did not disappear because Sweden became home, just as 20 years in Sweden did not erase where my story began. Maybe I was not from one origin at all, but stitched from several experiences into the person I now carry through the world. The next time someone asks me where I was from, I would, perhaps, pause, smile, and say: it depends on which part of me you are asking about.

The writer is a U.S.-based professional with an interest in travel and culture reporting.

GOREN BRIDGE

Leading away from the king

North-South vulnerable, West deals

Bob Jones East’s flimsy one-heart bid might have gotten his partner off to a heart lead, but West was likely to have led a heart anyway. The lead was an obvious singleton after East’s bid. South won the heart lead in dummy and led the king of spades, holding the trick. He cashed the king and queen of diamonds

before leading the jack of spades from dummy. West did not want to be stuck on lead with the ace, so he won the second spade and continued with a third. Declarer won in hand with the queen and led the ace of diamonds, discarding a low club from dummy. He knew that West held the ace of clubs for his opening bid, so he made no effort to lead a club toward his king. South simply led a low

club away from his king. West still did not want to be on lead so he played the two from his hand, which forced East to win the trick. East led the queen of hearts to dummy’s king and South led a club to his king and West’s ace. West was end-played and forced to give up a ruff-sluff. West led a club, so South ruffed in dummy while discarding a heart from his hand. Making four!

NORTH
♠ K J 10 9
♥ A K 8 7
♦ K Q
♣ 6 4 3

WEST
♠ A 8 6
♥ 2
♦ J 9 8 7 3
♣ A Q J 2

EAST
♠ 3
♥ Q J 10 6 4
♦ 10 5 4
♣ 10 9 8 5

SOUTH
♠ Q 7 5 4 2
♥ 9 5 3
♦ A 6 2
♣ K 7

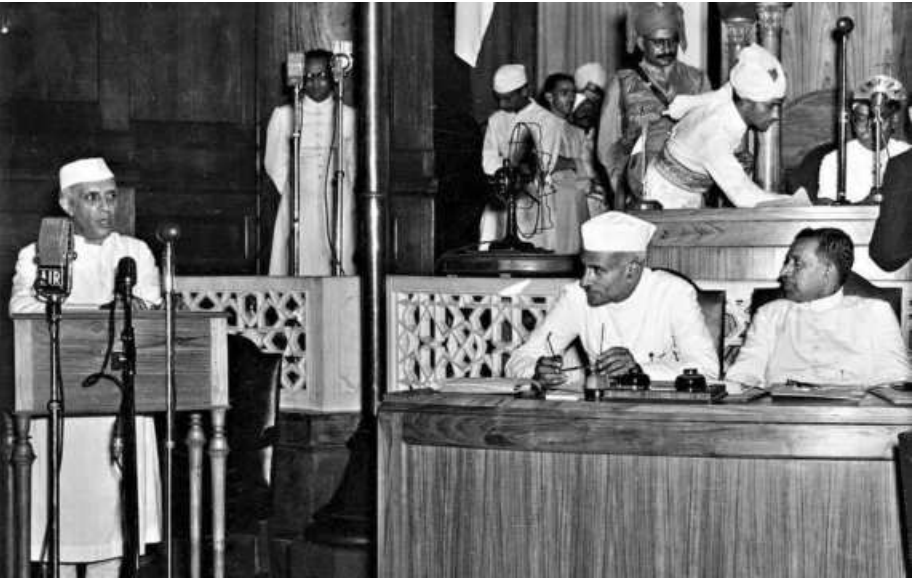
The bidding:
WEST 1♦
NORTH Dbl
EAST 1♥
SOUTH 2♠
Pass 4♠ All pass

Opening lead: Two of ♥

QUIZ

Easy like Sunday morning

At the stroke of the midnight hour...



Jawaharlal Nehru, the first Prime Minister of independent India, addresses Parliament on the eve of Independence. (WIKIMEDIA COMMONS)

Berty Ashley

Till its independence on August 15, 1947, India was under British rule. It became a sovereign democratic republic when the Constitution came into effect on January 26, 1950. What was India’s constitutional status during the time between these two dates? Until January 24, 1950, India did not have a formally adopted version of what is now an integral part of Independence Day ceremonies. It began as a Bengali hymn titled ‘Bharoto Bhagyo Bidhata’, by Rabindranath Tagore. Anandamath (The Abbey of Bliss), an 1882 Bengali novel by Bankim Chandra

Chattopadhyay, is set against the backdrop of the Bengal famine of 1770 and the Sannyasi Rebellion. In the story, a song meaning ‘I bow to thee, Mother’ is sung. What did this song become in 1950? The Indian Independence Act was passed on July 18, 1947. Lord Mountbatten, however, chose August 15 as the date of Indian independence, partly because August 15, 1945, was the day on which Emperor Hirohito announced Japan’s acceptance of the Potsdam Declaration. What global conflict did this announcement bring to an end? American jazz saxophonist and composer Ted Nash won the 2017 Grammy for Best Instrumental Composition for ‘Spoken at Midnight’. The track’s composition was inspired by the

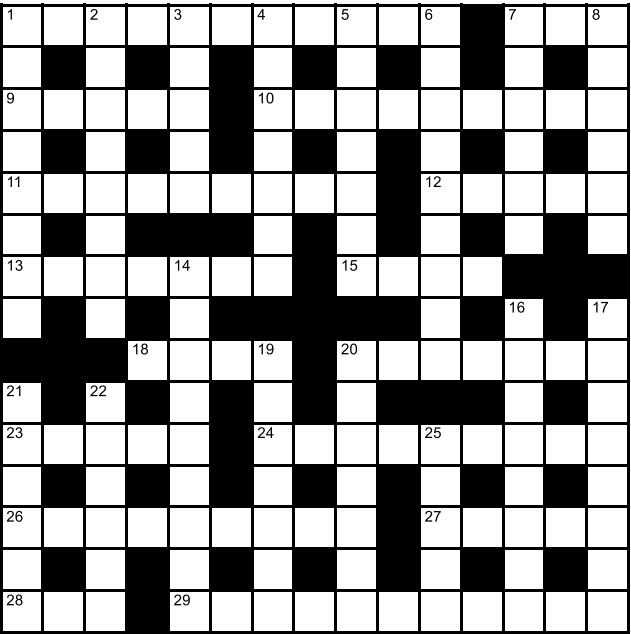
cadence and rhythm of a historic speech. Whose speech was it, and what was the title of the speech? This line of boundary splits two countries, one that gained its independence on August 14 and the other, India, on August 15. The demarcation line itself was only published on August 17 (two days later). By what name is this line known and which country’s border is it? After India attained independence, some territories within the subcontinent remained under foreign control. In 1961, the last of these was liberated from Portuguese rule and incorporated into India. Which was this territory? Until 1973, governors generally hoisted the national flag in the States on Independence

Day. The practice of Chief Ministers carrying out this tradition was introduced following a request by the then Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, who wrote to Prime Minister Indira Gandhi. Which Chief Minister, popularly known as ‘Kalaigarnar’ (scholar of the arts), was responsible for this change? Along with India, five other countries observe a national or independence-related occasion on August 15. Two of them mark their liberation from Japanese rule on August 15, 1945, and are separated by a De-Militarized Zone (DMZ). Which two countries are these? An important symbol at Independence Day ceremonies is manufactured using hand-spun and handwoven khadi cotton. The Karnataka Khadi Gramodyoga Samyukta Sangha, based in the Dharwad/ Hubbali region of Karnataka, is one of the authorised units associated with the manufacture and supply of an iconic symbol of India’s freedom. What item is this? A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’. @bertyashley

- 1. Dominion of India/ Union of India
- 2. Jana Gana Mana, the national anthem
- 3. The national song, ‘Vande Mataram’
- 4. World War II
- 5. Jawaharlal Nehru’s ‘Tryst with Destiny’ speech
- 6. Radcliffe Line/ Pakistan
- 7. Goa
- 8. M. Karunanidhi
- 9. North Korea and South Korea
- 10. The national flag

Answers

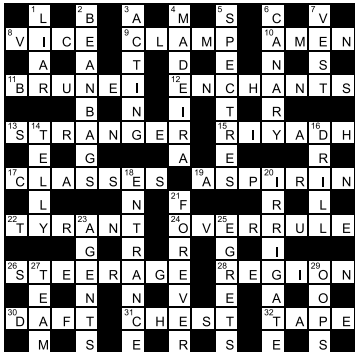
THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 69 (Set by Arden)



- Across**
- 1 Military orders to tolerate a ridicule (5,2,4)
 - 7 First of all safety — and people undermine it (3)
 - 9 Middle name in a mix up — they provide early life cover (5)
 - 10 Resistance to stop a film on murder — there’s no shooting (9)
 - 11 With money, bank becomes more determined (9)
 - 12 The bread winner brings it home... (5)
 - 13 ...and finally when the romantic ruler’s getting amorous (7)
 - 15 Defy and force the ruffian (4)
 - 18 Plans over canned meat? (4)
 - 20 Poet follows one as movement is slow (7)
 - 23 Daisy gets a stern warning to stay inside (5)
 - 24 New wine gets to head, shows unpleasantness (9)
 - 26 Short course on drinking French wine in various regions (9)
 - 27 Come right inside the club (5)
 - 28 Ultimately get to one digit (3)
 - 29 Dawdle around — days wasted finding top vegetable (5-6)
- Down**
- 1 School can make an impression while growing up (8)
 - 2 Declare the girl is overweight (8)
 - 3 Inside a thing at the end (5)
 - 4 Making fun of a drink with Carol (7)
 - 5 A young man crossed over the border, returned with top officer (7)

- 6 Oriental shock involving billions — going to China? (9)
- 7 Partners lie on long grass (6)
- 8 Praises break up involving a sweetheart (6)
- 14 Just me with broken Tamil, about average (9)
- 16 The ruler, having born before ‘50, is praying (8)
- 17 Males promise merchandise for a haberdashery (8)
- 19 Threatened people, one died later (7)
- 20 Helps musicians to leave Britain (7)
- 21 Castigate for reviewing some of the corporate practices (6)
- 22 Set to go out — no time for an underling (6)
- 25 Tinned fruit picked regularly for a lemur (5)

SOLUTION NO. 68



Shelley Walia
shelleywalia@gmail.com

As a war-torn West Asia trembles under the weight of relentless conflict, its devastation spills across the globe, inflating the price of bread and deepening the suffering of the poor. One is reminded that fear travels far beyond the battlefield, seeping deep into the ordinary rhythms of life.

It is in this climate of dread that I find myself sitting on the banks of Lake Lucerne, in a village called Brunnen in Switzerland. Across the water, I can see the Bürgenstock, the high mountain and luxury alpine resort, where J.D. Vance is said to have met the Iranian delegation in search of some resolution to the conflict between Iran and the United States. The bright day is darkening into evening, a cool wind is moving in steadily, and in my lap lies Alan Paton’s *Cry, the Beloved Country*, a novel I have returned to after many years. Some books simply do not age. They deepen their hold instead.

And so, this evening, I find myself thinking of Paton’s novel, often read as a lament against apartheid, but which is also something more enduring in the form of a meditation on what fear does to a nation, and to the child not yet born who inherits that fear. That warning feels uncannily contemporary tonight, as I sit anguished at the world’s unbridled belligerence, its sectarian violence, and the merciless toll of the wars in Ukraine, Gaza, and Iran.

As I read, my mind travels southward to Apartheid South Africa, to the long brutality that Alan Paton had spent his life resisting. And then, almost by accident, I find something I had completely forgotten, a yellowing newspaper cutting tucked into the back of the book, a piece by Anne Paton, Alan Paton’s wife, entitled *Fly, My Beloved Country*. It was written nearly three decades ago, describing why she had been compelled to leave the country she loved. She had never wanted to leave. But it had become impossible to stay. I sensed intense grief in that statement.

It is not Paton’s novel alone that haunts me now. It is the imagined, almost mythic, departure of Anne Paton from a continent already scarred by injustice. In my mind, her exit becomes a mirror of another great African farewell. Karen Blixen’s *Out of Africa* reminds me of the touching scene where, after the death of her lover, Denys Hatton, she sits in a small plane, looking down at the endless savannah, the animals moving in silent procession. In my memory, the haunting notes of Mozart’s Clarinet Concerto in A Minor swirl around her, its music at once tender and desolate, as though carrying the weight of leaving itself. The clarinet, an instrument of call and response, mirrors the dialogue between the departing individual and the land she leaves behind. It seems to ask, “Will you remember me?” and answers, “I will, even if I cannot stay.”

Reading Anne Paton again during my sojourn here surrounded by the Uri Alps in a quaint village on the lake, I am struck by the dignity of Anne’s



In the shadow of fear

A meditation on the world’s unbridled belligerence, its sectarian violence, and the merciless toll of wars in Ukraine, Gaza, and Iran

grief. Overwhelming rage and accusations would have been the usual response. But her departure resonates, inevitably, with a sense of the loss of a beloved country as the land recedes, still beautiful, still beloved, but no longer inhabitable. The moment of departure has always stayed with me as an ache of a dream that ruptures, the lover gone, the farm lost, the illusion of settlement undone.

Personal elegy
The book and film *Out of Africa* blend in my imagination resounding with the concerto arousing the gloom of Anne and Karen, both suspended between earth and sky, watching a world they loved and lost, and wondering whether any of it will ever be whole again. That image has become, for me, a personal elegy for every departure, every forced or chosen exile that leaves behind a landscape of both beauty and longing.

From England, where I was then based, the news from South Africa began to arrive in fragments, images of violence, of social breakdown, of a state increasingly unable to guarantee safety. This was no

I find myself thinking of Alan Paton’s novel, often read as a lament against Apartheid, but which is also something more enduring in the form of a meditation on what fear does to a nation, and to the child not yet born who inherits that fear

longer the South Africa of freedom one had dreamt of.

To love a country at such a moment is to experience that love as pain. Anne Paton’s admission captures the tragedy of nations that fail those who love them most. Departure, in such cases, becomes a compulsion, a breakaway, a form of interior exile.

For me, this is not a story confined to South Africa. It is a pattern that recurs across societies where political freedom arrives without the institutional and moral structures required to sustain it. And that is Paton’s enduring relevance. To love a country deeply is to risk being wounded by it. The greater the attachment, the sharper the loss. Perhaps that is the most difficult truth of all.

It returns now when I think of Anne Paton, the same quiet devastation, the same reluctant severance. Life continues, as it must, but something irrevocable has been left behind.

As I close this piece, I hear, in my mind, that distant clarinet. It reminds me that every departure carries with it a promise of return, however distant, and that the landscapes we leave behind continue to shape us, long after we have gone.

In remembering Anne Paton’s flight, and in recalling Blixen’s solitary plane ride, I am reminded that to love a place is to accept its inevitable loss, and to mourn that loss is, in its own way, a tribute to the enduring beauty of the beloved country.

I kept that newspaper cutting. I carry it still.

Much more than just a ride

Shreya Sundar
shreyasundar104@gmail.com

As I sit back and picture my college days, the endless and crowded bus journeys vividly cross my mind. What started out as the most tiresome part of the day soon became a routine. With a huge crowd huddled at the bus stop during the peak hours of the day, the journey truly felt like the survival of the fittest: those who were strong battled their way into the bus while the meek were left behind on an endless pursuit of waiting for the next bus.

Amid all this chaos, the wave of happiness that set in at the sight of an empty bus was simply unexplainable. Yet, the fight for the window seat remained eternal, the calculated moves people made to secure a seat in a crowded bus held me in awe. The most memorable rides were the one with friends whose presence made me forget the long journey as we chatted our way through the gruelling traffic.

Bus travel was a mode of transport that brought together people from different backgrounds. One could see college students wearing earphones blaring music loud enough to cancel the sounds of the outside world, schoolchildren clinging to their parents hoping not to be squished by the crowd, corporate employees lost in their thoughts and flower vendors bringing a fragrance into the bus with asaks of blossoms large enough to block the aisle. The conductor tirelessly shuttled back and forth making sure everyone got a ticket and setting an example for how determined a human can be.

It was not just a ride but a lesson in resilience and patience. Consumed by my college life, such philosophical thoughts often went unregistered but, deep down, my journeys by bus had a profound impact that I continue to cherish.

Seetha Jayakumar
seethajayan@gmail.com

The journey is about the destination, they say. I beg to differ. Sometimes, it’s about the toilet breaks in between. We are on a trip with a group of friends, ticking one more tourist destination off our bucket list. The mood on the tourist bus is joyful and everyone is buzzing after the hearty breakfast we just had, except me.

“Hope there are toilet breaks in between,” I say as soon as I settle down. I silently scold myself for all the tea I had.

“Are you here for a holiday break or a toilet break?” my college-going daughter teases.

“Can’t enjoy the first one without the second,” I say.

I am not obsessed with toilets, but years of road trips across the country have left me acutely aware of one truth – a beautiful holiday can quickly become miserable if there isn’t a decent toilet break when you need one.

“Don’t worry, Amma. I think there is a toilet on the bus,” comforts my daughter.

“It’s not working, madam,” says the driver before I could let out a relieved phew.

My bladder starts misbehaving immediately. The bus is air-conditioned, set perhaps at the lowest possible temperature point, god knows why. The place we have to go to is a good three hours away. It’s all psychological, I tell myself. Just don’t think about it.

“We’ll stop at a toilet on

Toilet travails on the road

How a dream trip can be spoiled by the lack of this necessity



the way,” says the driver.

I heave a huge sigh of relief. My husband lets out a cackle. “It’s different for you guys. You can go wherever you want,” I grumble.

Long queues
The road to our destination is beautiful. Lush green hills roll past us and tiny streams sparkle in the sunlight. While everyone is oohing and aahing at the scenery, all I can think of is that toilet waiting somewhere for me. True to his word, the driver stops the bus at a small roadside food court with a cute eatery and a toilet tucked away at the back. The bus empties all of a sudden, people queuing for either food or

the toilet. By the time I climb down from my middle seat (specially selected for comfort and motion sickness), there’s already a long queue outside the ladies’ toilet. The men’s queue moves quickly. Before my turn comes, the bus driver signals it’s time to leave.

“Hurry up, madam. We have to be there in one hour if we want to make it in time for the boat rides,” he says.

With a heavy heart and an even heavier bladder, I

hurry back to the bus. My husband and my daughter are already in their seats, munching on *pakor*as and sipping cool drinks. They offer me one. I say no. No input, without output.

“You’ll be fine,” says my husband, trying to reassure me unsuccessfully.

My throat is parched and my lips dry, but I decide to stay dehydrated for the next hour. As soon as we reach the destination, I begin searching for a toilet. I smell one before I spot it and decide to stay away. My daughter, who’s now beginning to show some empathy, joins my search.

So while the others admire the hills and the lake, and get ready for their boat rides, we scan the area for a toilet. Even after 15 minutes of frantic searching, we don’t spot one. But we do notice a posh hotel nearby. My daughter looks at me with a glint in her eye. I get the hint. “Let’s go,” I tell her, “there’s no other way”.

So off we go into the hotel, walking past the freshly polished lobby towards the restaurant. Tables, chairs, potted plants, dessert displays and yes, there it is. A door with gents’ and ladies’ stick figures. Never in my life has a stick figure brought me so much joy.

While my daughter orders tea and cake, I scramble for the restroom. Ten minutes later, we step out of the hotel, my wallet lighter by a few hundred rupees, but my heart and bladder infinitely lighter. I was finally ready for the destination, now that I had survived the journey.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the *Magazine* can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Ladakh’s traditional yak cheese gaining international recognition is encouraging, but the larger challenge is sustaining yak herding. (‘How Ladakh landed on the cheese map’; Aug. 9) Better veterinary services, cold storage, fair procurement and reliable transport can improve the earnings of ordinary yak herders like Thenlay Nurboo.

A. Myilsami

It is true that consumers only look for high-quality products, but the arduous effort and perseverance that goes into their preparation are rarely considered or discussed. In this fast-paced world, people who still want to continue their traditional occupation are rare.

Sajna Hameed

Remembering an icon

Sumana Roy has done a great service by translating Jagadish Chandra Bose’s book so more people can read it. (‘The language of leaves’; Aug. 9) This is a celebration of a scientist who made seminal contributions to the advancement of plant science.

Kosaraju Chandramouli

Nature at its best

The relationship between trees and people as enumerated in T.R. Shankar Raman’s book is moving and informative. (‘Secret histories of India’s trees’; Aug. 9) The simple narrative educates readers about lesser-known species and the need to protect them.

Monita Sutherson

Forgotten artists

The conversation made

for excellent reading. (‘Going beyond Ravi Varma’; Aug. 9) Through such dialogues, we relish and realise the creativity that is hidden in the chronicles of time and space. The conversation asks pertinent questions about the likes of Ramaswamy Naidu who is not remembered in the same breath as Ravi Varma.

Balasubramaniam Pavani

Visual storytelling

India’s long tradition of visual storytelling deserves greater public attention. (‘Before manga, India had murals’; Aug. 9) Exhibitions that connect murals, temple narratives and modern comics can help younger generations understand this continuity. Museums should document regional traditions, support restoration and create accessible digital archives.

Pon Arun Kumar

Art for posterity

Art can preserve memories of places undergoing rapid social and physical change. (‘Dreaming of the Valley’; Aug. 9) Artists working from such experiences deserve spaces where their work can be viewed without being reduced to political labels. Galleries and cultural institutions should encourage regional artists, provide residencies and support documentation, helping diverse perspectives remain in India’s cultural record.

P.S. Harishmitha

The physical distance has enabled Azim Hassan to look at his homeland differently and see its contrasting realities together — its beauty as well as its wounds.

S. Sundareswara Pandiyan



MORE ON THE WEB

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The riddle of trauma

It’s a word with much greater meaning and depth, and should not be misused

Cerin Pathrose

Schooldays, punishments, and the red stage

Schools have been encouraged to adopt more constructive and child-friendly approaches to discipline

Vijay Shekhar

A few kind words

Give the compliment, appreciate someone’s effort

Pushpanjali Rout

The 1990s experience

The generation has seen technologies emerge, change, adapt and vanish

Ashok Balakrishna

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Bishnupur in West Bengal is famous for its exquisite terracotta temples. But while there, I was drawn to Rabankata, a 400-year-old folk dance drama rooted in the Ramayana. The performers wear heavy wooden masks and vibrant costumes made from dyed jute fibres.



I met two Rabari families — an indigenous tribe of nomadic shepherds — who had pitched their tents on the outskirts of Udaipur. Every year, they moved between Indore in Madhya Pradesh and Sirohi in Rajasthan. Now, the younger generation is opting for permanent settlement by taking up government jobs.

How a photographer travelled five years, 21,000 kilometres, to 28 states, and over 180 villages to befriend strangers and learn the everyday routines of his country

THE GEOGRAPHY OF TRUST



(From top) An elderly man from the Apatani tribe threshing paddy in a traditional basket; two sisters from Jharkhand's Santhal Pargana region wearing matching gold nose rings gifted by their father; and Navin Paul.

Navin Paul

In 2021, I started cycling across India with a Nikon D850 camera and a loose plan to photograph whatever I found along the way — people, places, small routines of everyday life. I wanted to step away from a fixed routine and spend more time on the road, and cycling, with its slower pace, seemed the best way to do it.

It wasn't meant to be a long project. And yet five years passed as I got to know the people of my country, and the journey turned into nearly 21,000 kilometres across 28 states and more than 180 villages.

From curiosity to conversations

On the road, my days were simple, with no set itinerary. I cycled in the cooler morning hours, covering anywhere between 60 and 100 kilometres depending on the terrain and weather. Afternoons were for resting, finding shade under toll gates and roadside shelters.

The chaos of big cities had me peddling on (Kolkata was an exception, with the contrast between the old and the new) while I paused for days in smaller towns and villages. Most evenings, one question would come up: where would I sleep? I got used to asking strangers for a place to stay, though it never became easy. In the beginning, people said “no” more often than “yes”. Some were polite, some direct. A few simply walked away. It made sense; I was an outsider, asking for trust without offering much in return.

But there were always exceptions. Someone would ask a question, then another. Where are you coming from? How long have you been on the road? Those small conversations shifted something. In Murudeshwara, Karnataka, I had planned to sleep by the beach after a long ride. I had already picked a spot when I met a fisherman. We spoke for a few minutes, then he asked if I had eaten. I hadn't. He took me home, and that night I sat with his family and ate a simple meal of freshly caught fish and rice.

In Kohima, Nagaland, I arrived during the rice planting season and ended up staying with a farming family for a few days. The work in the fields began early. The men prepared the land, while the women followed planting saplings in steady lines. At some point, their rhythm turned to song. I remember trying to keep up for a while, then giving up. Our conversations tried to find parallels between food and farming in Nagaland and Kerala. It felt less like something I was documenting and more like something I had briefly become a part of.

Even birthdays were celebrated on the road. I remember my 28th; I was in Pokhran, Rajasthan, staying at a gurdwara. The head saw my ID and asked me what I'd like as a present. I joked I'd like to drive a tractor. “That's easy,” he said, and showed me how to handle one before letting me take the wheel.

Fragments of stories

Travelling by cycle changed the way I arrived in places. It slowed everything down. I stayed longer, and it often made it easier for people to approach me. They wanted to know what was the best place I'd visited so far; did people elsewhere live lives just like theirs. I remember the people in Ladakh being curious about the South, and how it was to live beside beaches!

Sometimes, language became a barrier, but a way was always found. In Srinagar, Jammu and Kashmir, I stopped at a roadside shop and, as always, people gathered around. Conversations were held through gestures and the few words we each understood. In time, one of them offered me a place to stay for a few days after heavy rains delayed my plan to ride towards Sonamarg. Before I left, his wife knitted a Kashmiri cap and gifted it to me.

If five years on the road has taught me anything, it is that while India's landscapes, languages and traditions change constantly, its people don't. Behind unfamiliar clothes and customs are familiar traits — generosity, hospitality, the ability to find joy in small things, a love of food and sharing it. I hold dear the memories of the old man on the outskirts of Shillong who shared a meal of red rice and black sesame pork with me; the people in Kunkeshwar in coastal Maharashtra and Bastar in Chhattisgarh who exclaimed, “Your parents must be very brave [because I was an only son on a long journey].”

Looking back, what stands out isn't the distance covered, but the number of times someone chose to trust me, welcome me into a small part of their lives when they didn't have to. This work is now coming together as a photobook, not as a complete story but as fragments of many.

The writer is a photographer and adventurer documenting people and cultures across India.



(Top) A woman walking through newly planted terraced paddy fields in Kigwema, Nagaland; and (above) Chhau artists rehearsing for a ‘nach’ — their movements fierce, their masks transforming them into gods. (ALL IMAGES BY NAVIN PAUL)

In Arunachal Pradesh's West Kameng district, a Brokpa man stood in quiet awe before an ancient, colossal tree, carrying the weight of ancestral stories in its gnarled branches.

Facing challenges on Trooper

I named my road bicycle Trooper, and it carried everything I needed: my camera gear, tent and clothes. Selling photo prints (edited on Photoshop and Lightroom) and using my savings helped sustain my travels. Five years threw several challenges my way. Cycling in Ladakh through sub-zero temperatures pushed me to my limits, as did the desert temperatures of Rajasthan. In the Northeast, heavy monsoon rains and landslides left me stranded for almost 18 months. One vivid memory is being stuck in Tripura's Jampui Hills after a landslide washed away part of the road behind me. A shopkeeper offered me space, and I pitched my tent under a partially broken roof till the road was cleared.

The project — which started on March 3, 2021, from my hometown of Kottayam in Kerala, and concluded on July 26, 2026 — wasn't always easy to carry forward. But calls with family and close friends helped ground me. I returned home twice in those five years, and those breaks allowed me to rest and reset.